

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS



INDIA-SRI LANKA - 1

MODULE - 27

INDIA AND SRI LANKA

1 The relationship between India and Sri Lanka's is 2,500 years old and covers various dimensions- intellectual, cultural, religious and linguistic.

2 In the recent years, the relationship has been strengthened by political exchanges, flourishing bilateral trade, mutually beneficial relations in areas of defence, health and education.

The relations can be divided into several phases

- Ancient/Historical period
- Colonial period
- Milestones of Post Independence
- Contemporary Relations



ANCIENT PERIOD

1 In the Ancient period, Buddhism was said to have been introduced into Sri Lanka in the 4th century BC by the son of Indian Emperor Ashoka.

2 The first monasteries and Buddhist monuments in the country were established during this time

3 Sri Lanka has a long history of Buddhism with Mahayana Buddhism surviving in the country.

4 The Tamil community in Sri Lanka, introduced Hinduism and Tamil Language in the country.



COLONIAL PERIOD

1 During the colonial period, the concept of 'strategic unity' between India and Sri Lanka emerged

2 For the British the possession of Sri Lanka was an imperative for the defence of India.

3 Sri Lanka feared that India would retain the British imperial legacy in South Asia even after independence.

4 It thus, entered into a Defence Agreement with Britain India and joined the Commonwealth

5 The Constitution of Sri Lanka favoured the Sinhalese language and Buddhist religion. The Sinhalese population curbed the Tamil community in the areas of education and civil administration.

6 The Sinhalese Only Bill tried to alienate the Tamil community from the other sections of the population

What was the policy?

Official Language Act, 1956

What was it about?

1. Changed official language from English to Sinhala
2. Tamils in government service given three years to learn Sinhala or be dismissed

What did it result in?
(Impact)

The policy upset many Tamils, who organized a peaceful demonstration against the policy. However, the peaceful demonstration turned into violent riots when it was disrupted by supporters of the Sinhala language.

MILESTONES OF POST INDEPENDENCE

1. Sirima Shastri Pact
2. Indira Gandhi and Tamil Issue
3. Katchatheevu Issue
4. Indo-Sri Lankan Maritime Agreement
5. Ethnic Problem in Sri Lanka
6. IPKF in Sri Lanka
7. Indo-Sri Lanka Accord
8. Withdrawal of IPKF
9. Look East Policy
10. Gujral Doctrine



COMMERCIAL PLANTATION IN SRI LANKA

- 1 In 1833, the Colebrook reforms were introduced by the British, which had transformed the socio-economic condition in Sri Lanka.
- 2 Capitalist economy was set up and participation of private sector was encouraged. Commercial Plantation was authorized
- 3 British brought workers from South India for plantation. These workers were proficient in cultivation of Tea and it provided cheap labour for the British
- 4 But the problem arose after independence of Sri Lanka when the Citizenship Act of 1949 took away the legal citizen statuses of the Indian workers
- 5 To resolve the issue, PM Mrs Bandaranaike visited India in 1964 and the Sirima-Shastri pact was signed on 30 October, 1964.



SIRIMA – SHASTRI PACT

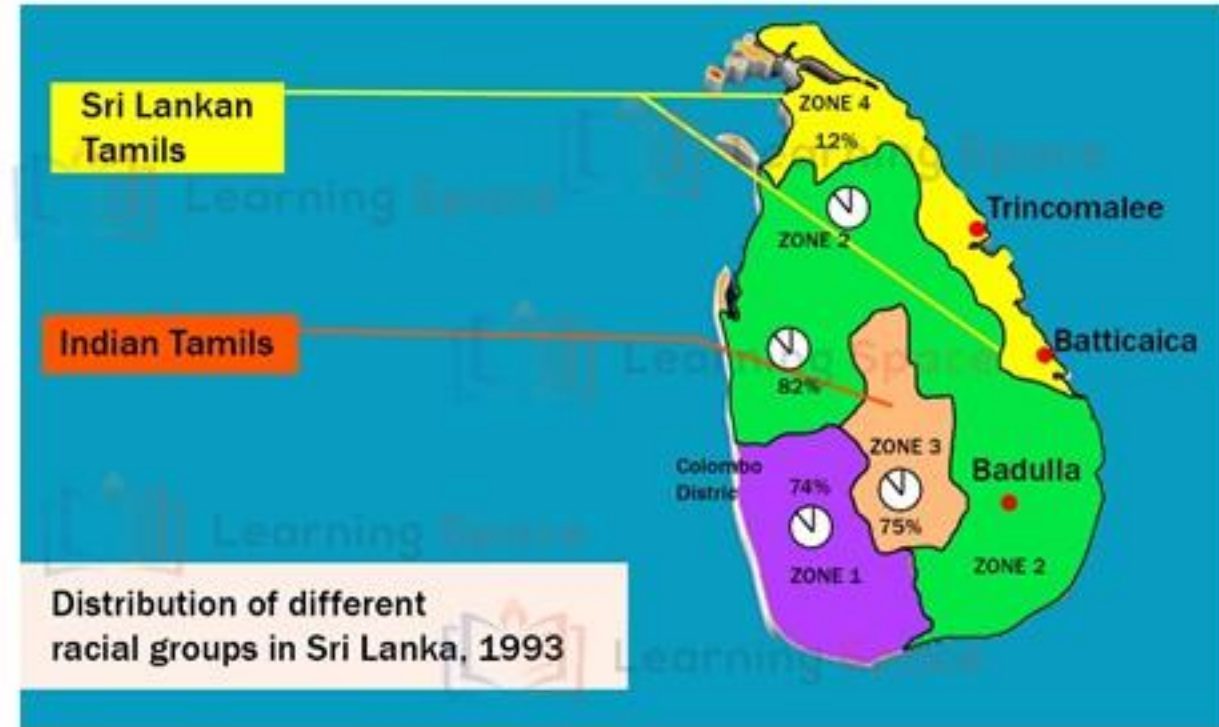
The pact decided upon the following

- 1 The people of Indian origin, residing in Ceylon, who were not citizens of either India or Ceylon; were to become citizens of either India or Ceylon
- 2 In this regard the Indian government would accept repatriations of persons within a period of 15 days of the signing of the pact.
- 3 Moreover, Ceylon would allow those people who were employed during the signing of this pact to continue with their jobs until the date of their repatriation.



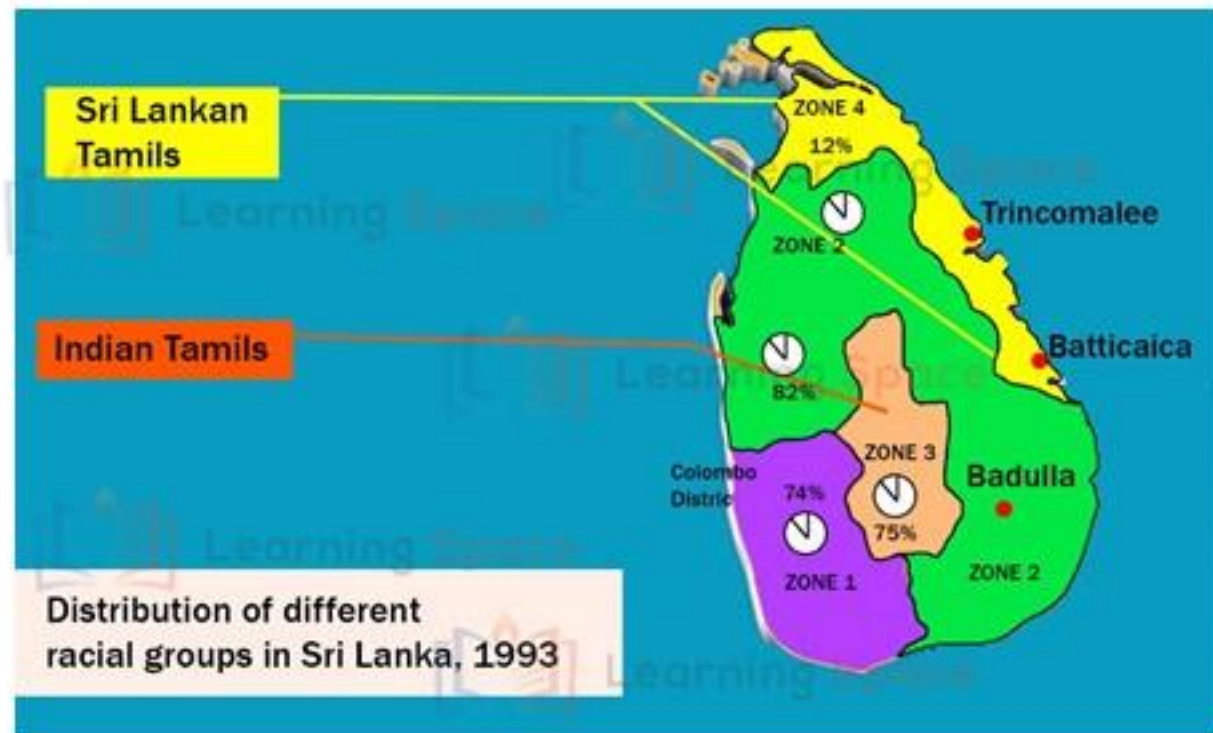
ETHNIC PROBLEM IN SRI LANKA

- 1 Sri Lanka is multi-religious and multi-ethnic country.
- 2 This diversity has a regional basis adding a geographical dimension to the issue of Tamil militancy and the LTTE's demand for a separate state for themselves.
- 3 Sri Lanka, which was caught in a bloody civil war between the Sinhala majority and the Tamil minority.
- 4 Sinhala was imposed as the sole 'official language' of the island nation.



ETHNIC PROBLEM IN SRI LANKA

- 5 The Tamils asked for parity for their own tongue and, when this was denied, took to the streets in protest.
- 6 Until the early 1980s, ethnic conflict was confined to political discussions. However, after the early 1980s, institutionalized political violence began and Tamil youth organized themselves into armed guerrilla outfits. This led to mobilization and brutalization of the Sri Lankan ethnic conflict.



INDIRA GANDHI IN SRI LANKA

1 During the Cold War, India was suspicious of Sri Lanka because it was aligned with the US.

2 PM Indira Gandhi on the issue of Tamil Eelam movement of the 1980s, asked Britain to not help Sri Lanka with military aid and anti-insurgency assistance.

3 The issue of Tamil liberation concerned people of Indian origin and India wanted a resolution of the issue.

4 India was giving military training, funding and weapons to the militant groups to set up base in Tamil Nadu

5 India began getting refugees from Sri Lanka in 1983. In 1983, PM Gandhi asserted that India will not take refugees from Sri Lanka and that India follows the principle of non-refoulement and voluntary repatriation.



KATCHATHEEVU

- 1** Katchatheevu is an uninhabited islet in the Palk Strait owned by the Raja of Ramnad (Ramanathapuram). Pilgrims from both India and Sri Lanka used to visit the island
- 2** In 1921, both Sri Lanka and India claimed this piece of land for ideal for fishing.
- 3** In 1974, the Indo-Sri Lankan Maritime agreement was signed between PM Gandhi and PM Bandaranaike to address the dispute by ceding the islet to Sri Lanka.



KATCHATHEEVU

- 4 This agreement did not specify fishing rights and allowed Indian fishermen to fish around Katchatheevu and to dry their nets on the island.
- 5 The central government in India recognizes Sri Lanka's sovereignty over the island as per 1974 accord.
- 6 But Tamil Nadu claimed that Katchatheevu falls under the Indian territory and Tamil fishermen have traditionally believed that it belongs to them.



INDO-SRI LANKAN MARITIME AGREEMENT

Another agreement was signed in 1976 to fill gaps of the earlier agreement. Under this

- 1 The boundary between India and Sri Lanka in the Gulf of Mannar and Bay of Bengal was determined and Exclusive Economic Zones were demarcated.
- 2 The agreement restricted both the countries' fishermen from fishing in the other's waters.
- 3 Sovereign rights over the living and non-living things in their respective zones.



WHY INDIA ACCEPTED THE CEDING?

- 1 After the nuclear test of May 1974, India was under enormous pressure from International Communities. India needed some support and Sri Lanka was ready to help.
- 2 Sri Lanka's support was also important because it was likely that president of United Nations General Assembly would be from Sri Lanka.
- 3 Moreover, Sri Lanka was to host Non Aligned Movement summit for the year 1976.
- 4 Hence, PM Gandhi acted in the situation in 1974 without discussion in Parliament or Tamil Nadu.
- 5 But because it is not ratified, the validity of the agreement remains a question and the worst sufferers of this indecision are the fishermen.



LIBERATION TIGERS OF TAMIL ELAM

- 1 The failure of parliamentary politics and entrenchment of ethnic politics led to frustration among Tamil youth and they organized themselves into armed groups seeking independence from Sinhalese domination.
- 2 Most radical of these groups was known as the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Elam or LTTE.
- 3 Led by a brutal fighter named Velupillai Prabhakaran, the LTTE had as its aim a separate nation, to be constituted from the north and east of the island, where the Tamils were in a majority



LIBERATION TIGERS OF TAMIL ELAM

- 4 LTTE fighters had used the Indian state of Tamil Nadu as a safe haven. Their activities were actively helped by the state government
- 5 They made particularly effective use of land mines, blowing up convoys of soldiers as they travelled on the roads
- 6 In 1987, the political violence included bombing the Sinhalese dominated south. Eventually, the conflict reached civil war proportions and Indian peacekeeping forces were sent to Sri Lanka in 1987.



INDIAN PEACEKEEPING FORCE

- 1 In 1987, the Sri Lankan President, J. R. Jayawardene asked PM Rajiv Gandhi to help mediate in the conflict and the Indian Peacekeeping Force (IPKF), known as Operation Pawan was deployed in Sri Lanka from 1987 to 1990.
- 2 The objective was to make the Sri Lankan army retreat and persuade or force the LTTE militants to disarm.
- 3 India's ambition of growing as a regional hegemon in South Asia prompted this decision.
- 4 During this time, India dominated the region demographically and economically . It wanted to express this dominance in terms of military preparedness as well.
- 5 This argument is validated because this intervention did not abide by the IPC act in terms of impartiality and the level of force that was used.



INDIAN PEACEKEEPING FORCE

- 6 According to Amnesty International, prisoners detained by the Indians have been reportedly tortured with electric shock treatment.
- 7 The Jaffna report praised individual Indian officers for stopping exercises of undisciplined troops, but detailed evidence of destruction of several Tamil communities in Sri Lanka.
- 8 The Indian forces left in 1990 and the civil conflict between the Government and LTTE resumed three months later.
- 9 The Union Minister of state for external affairs noted that the decision to send the Indian peacekeeping forces to Sri Lanka in 1987 was a 'high level political failure'
- 10 In the meantime, the leaders, Rajiv Gandhi and Jayewardene signed the India-Sri Lanka accord in Colombo in July 1987



INDO-SRI LANKAN ACCORD

- 1** The India-Sri Lanka accord envisaged the setting up of provincial councils with devolved power and ad hoc unification of the Tamil speaking Northern and Eastern provinces.
- 2** The 13th amendment was enacted to give effect to the accord envisaged the devolution of power over land and police.
- 3** The Indian Peace Keeping Force was sent to implement the accord. However, the LTTE rejected the accord and attacked the IPKF in October 1987.



LTTE DISAPPOINTED

- 1 Sinhala nationalists saw it as an infringement of sovereignty.
- 2 The Tamils, who had always thought that India was on their side were disappointed.
- 3 When asked to surrender their arms, the LTTE insisted on a series of preconditions, including the release of all Tamil prisoners in government custody and a halt to Sinhala colonization in the east of the island.
- 4 The LTTE headquarters in Jaffna was stormed and captured, but at an enormous cost.
- 5 Disappointed with India's actions, a LTTE activist killed PM Rajiv Gandhi in a suicide attack



WITHDRAWAL OF IPKF

- 1 VP Singh government decided to withdraw the IPKF on the argument that Sri Lanka wanted to withdraw, so India had to oblige.
- 2 The decision disregarded India's desire to place its foot print in the Indian ocean region and its effect on the Army.
- 3 Thus the war ended in March 1990 with the withdrawal of IPKF.
- 4 In 2012, during the armed conflict in Sri Lanka, India put in place a robust program of assistance to help the Internally Displaced People (IDPs). This included reviving of their agriculture and providing them with seeds.



EELAM WARS

SECOND EELAM WAR

- Soon after the IPKF was withdrawn, the LTTE militants armed themselves and began a second Sri Lankan Civil War called the Second Eelam War between 1990-95.

THIRD EELAM WAR

- The world scenario after the 9/11 attacks and the war on terror restricted international funding and support for LTTE militants.
- US aided Sri Lankan government to contain the civil war
- Ultimately after 26 years, in May 2009, the Sri Lankan government won over the Tamil Tigers.



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